



IFDC RESOURCE • NO. 5

IFDC REPORTING GUIDE

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# TRAUMA-SENSITIVE REPORTING OF CHILDREN

*How Sri Lankan journalists can report on child trauma without causing further harm*

A PUBLICATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD

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Trauma-informed practice has become standard in healthcare, education and the justice system — and it belongs in journalism too. Reporting through a trauma-aware lens does not soften the truth; it produces more accurate stories while protecting children and survivors from being harmed a second time by the reporting process itself.

## From ‘Victim’ to ‘Survivor’

Trauma-sensitive journalism shifts the frame from “what’s wrong” with a person to “what happened” to them and, where possible, to “what’s strong” about how they have coped. This is not euphemism — it is accuracy. A child who has experienced abuse is not defined by that experience, and language that treats them as dignified survivors rather than permanent victims tends to produce both better journalism and less harm.

## What Media Coverage Can Do to a Child

- Make a child feel unsafe, or convinced something bad is about to happen to them or their family.
- Create the impression that a single frightening event is recurring constantly, rather than being replayed footage of one incident.
- Disrupt sleep and concentration at school as the child dwells on what they've seen or heard.
- Heighten anxiety that a similar event could happen to them.

The more coverage a child is exposed to — including coverage not directed at them, such as news playing in the background at home — the more likely they are to become distressed.

## Guideline Set 1: Working With Survivors

1. Understand how trauma affects the brain. Memory, perception and judgement are all altered under acute stress; survivors and eyewitnesses often recall detail more accurately once they are further from the event, not immediately after it.
2. Go beyond a one-line consent form. Explain plainly what “on background” or “off the record” actually mean — survivors may be encountering this terminology, and significant distress, for the first time.
3. Bring survivors into the storytelling process: share questions in advance, let them choose what to answer, and let them review their own quotes before publication.
4. Respect “no.” A survivor is never obligated to talk. Leave contact details and let them reach out later, without pressure.
5. Remember the ripple effect — trauma radiates outward to families and communities, not just the person directly affected. Avoid saturating coverage with distressing detail beyond what the story needs.
6. If you plan to revisit or republish a survivor's story later, tell them in advance so they are not blindsided.
7. Protect your own wellbeing. Journalists who cover traumatic events repeatedly are themselves at risk of secondary trauma — seek support and maintain a sustainable routine.

## Guideline Set 2: Newsroom Standards

### Preparation

- Build baseline knowledge of child abuse, trauma effects, and available referral pathways.
- Know the local resources — in Sri Lanka, this includes the NCPA's 1929 Childline and the Women and Children's helpline 119.
- Build working relationships with psychologists, paediatricians and counsellors who can be consulted for context or comment.

## Respect and Sensitivity

- Never frame a story in a way that blames a child victim or their family.
- Stick to verified detail — avoid speculation about what a child experienced or felt.
- Avoid scheduling distressing child-trauma segments for hours when children are likely to be watching.
- Give warning before graphic content airs.
- Do not interview child victims or very young children directly; obtain parental consent before interviewing teenage witnesses.
- Keep parents informed before a story involving their child runs.

## Confidentiality

- Conceal the identity of the child and their family wherever possible.
- Avoid showing a child's face or any identifiable feature.
- Watch for indirect identification — enough detail about a perpetrator, a school, or a neighbourhood can reveal a child's identity even without naming them.
- Avoid broadcasting a child's 911-equivalent emergency call (in Sri Lanka, 119) unless essential to the story and cleared with a parent or guardian.

## Offering the Public Something Useful

- Include information on support resources and concrete steps people can take.
- Where possible, note when a child is receiving help or expected to recover — audiences need hope alongside the difficult facts.
- Educate the public on prevention, not only on the incident itself.

## Newsroom Oversight

- Make adherence to trauma-sensitive standards a condition of employment, not a personal preference.
- Put a real process behind it — review, escalation, and correction when standards are missed.
- Provide ongoing training on child trauma reporting, ideally through bodies such as the Sri Lanka College of Journalism or the Press Complaints Commission of Sri Lanka.

## Guideline Set 3: Helping Sri Lankan Families Cope With Coverage

### Monitor Exposure

- Assume children see and hear more news than adults expect — including via social media, not just television.
- Watch for signs of anxiety, especially in children directly or indirectly connected to an event.
- Avoid leaving distressing news running as background noise, and use parental controls where available.

### Talk It Through

- Reassure children by putting risk into realistic context.

- Make time to listen, answer honestly and simply, and respect a child's choice not to talk about it.
- Share your own feelings carefully — modelling that it's normal to feel upset, without overwhelming a younger child.

## Build Media Literacy

- Help older children understand bias and how to identify a credible outlet.
- Encourage comparing coverage across sources rather than relying on one feed or platform.
- Highlight stories of community resilience and support that typically follow difficult events.

### CONCLUSION

Trauma-sensitive reporting is not about avoiding hard stories — Sri Lankan media will continue to cover child abuse, accidents and disasters that affect children. It is about doing so in a way that minimises additional harm to the children and families already living through them.

*Paraphrased and adapted with Sri Lankan context by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), drawing on the Trauma-Informed Journalism Toolkit (Braden, L., 2023, Campaign for Trauma-Informed Policy and Practice), best-practice guidance compiled by J. Cain, and resources published by the Dart Center for Journalism and Trauma ([dartcenter.org](http://dartcenter.org)) and the National Child Traumatic Stress Network ([nctsn.org](http://nctsn.org)). © IFDC — [www.ifdchild.org](http://www.ifdchild.org).*

## GET HELP · REPORT A CONCERN · KNOW YOUR RESOURCES

*Sri Lankan Bodies Every Journalist Covering Children Should Know*

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### **EDITORS' GUILD OF SRI LANKA**

No. 96, Kirula Road, Colombo 05, Sri Lanka

Self-regulatory body for editors — Code of Professional Practice

### **PRESS COMPLAINTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (PCCSL)**

96 Bernard Soysa Mawatha (Kirula Road), Colombo 00500

Web: [www.pccsl.lk](http://www.pccsl.lk)

Independent Dispute Resolution Council for complaints against the press

### **HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (HRCSL)**

No. 14, R. A. De Mel Mawatha, Colombo 04

Tel: 011 250 5580 / 011 250 5581 / 011 250 5582 · Hotline: 1996

Web: [www.hrcsl.lk](http://www.hrcsl.lk)

### **LEGAL AID COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA**

No. 129, Hulftsdorp Street, Colombo 12

Tel: +94 11 243 3618 / +94 11 533 5329 / +94 11 533 5281

Email: [legalaids@sltnet.lk](mailto:legalaids@sltnet.lk) · Web: [www.legalaids.gov.lk](http://www.legalaids.gov.lk)

Free legal advice and court representation for eligible persons, including in child-related matters

### **NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION AUTHORITY (NCPA)**

No. 330, Thalawathugoda Road, Madiwela, Sri Lanka

Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24 hours, trilingual) · Tel: +94 11 277 8911–14

Email: [ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk](mailto:ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk) · Web: [www.childprotection.gov.lk](http://www.childprotection.gov.lk)

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